ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

General IT English

Conversation lab

12 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.

2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.

3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.

4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.

5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Service Desk Escalation: 'VPN Is Broken'

A remote employee reports that the VPN connects, but the finance system will not load.

Roles: User / Service desk / IT operations engineer

User: The VPN is broken again. I cannot get to finance.

Service desk: I understand the impact. Can I confirm one detail: does the VPN show connected, or does the connection fail completely?

User: It says connected.

IT operations engineer: Then we should avoid calling this a VPN outage yet. It may be DNS, routing, firewall, or the finance app itself. Are other internal sites loading?

User: The intranet loads, but finance times out.

IT operations engineer: Thank you. I will update the ticket as 'VPN connected; finance app unreachable over VPN for one user.' I am checking whether this is user-specific or app-wide before escalating.

User: I will check the application status with the service owner.

IT operations engineer: Please keep the ticket scope precise while we determine how many users are affected.

Notice the professional language

DNS - The system that resolves names such as app.example.com to network addresses.

VPN - A protected tunnel that allows remote users or sites to access private resources.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

P1 Incident Bridge: DNS or Application Outage?

Multiple users cannot reach a customer portal after a DNS change.

Roles: Incident commander / Network engineer / IT operations engineer / App owner

Incident commander: We need a clear status. Is the portal down?

Network engineer: The application servers are healthy. DNS queries are returning the old address for some users.

IT operations engineer: Current evidence points to inconsistent name resolution after the change. Let's compare resolver responses and the change timeline, then assess mitigation through the authorized incident and change process. Lowering a TTL now would not retroactively expire records already cached elsewhere.

App owner: Can we say the application is not the cause?

IT operations engineer: We can say current evidence points to DNS propagation, not application health. We should avoid final root-cause language until we review the change timeline and resolver logs.

Incident commander: I will compare the resolver evidence with the approved change record.

IT operations engineer: Then we can evaluate mitigation without calling the root cause final too early.

Notice the professional language

DNS - The system that resolves names such as app.example.com to network addresses.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Access Review: Urgent Admin Permission

A senior manager asks for admin rights to fix a reporting dashboard before a board meeting.

Roles: Manager / IT lead / IT operations engineer

Manager: Just give me admin access for today. I know what I am doing.

IT lead: We want to help with the deadline, but permanent admin rights are not the right control.

IT operations engineer: We can assess a time-limited privileged session with approval, logging, and a defined task scope under our access process. We need to verify that the access expires as intended.

Manager: That sounds slow.

IT operations engineer: I can help submit the request and identify the authorized reviewer. I cannot promise approval or an exception before that review.

Manager: I will specify the task and duration in the request.

IT operations engineer: That gives the reviewer a clear scope for the access decision.

Notice the professional language

Least privilege can be framed as protection, not obstruction.

Offer a controlled path rather than only saying no.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Patch Window Negotiation

Security wants to patch a critical vulnerability; operations worries about downtime during month-end close.

Roles: Security / Operations / IT operations engineer

Security: This CVE is being actively exploited. We need the patch tonight.

Operations: Tonight is month-end close. If the ERP system is down, finance cannot finish.

IT operations engineer: We have two risks: exploitation if we wait, and business disruption if the patch fails. Can we test the patch in staging now, apply compensating controls tonight, and schedule production for the first safe window?

Security: What controls?

IT operations engineer: Restrict exposure, increase monitoring, block known indicators, and require rollback approval before any production change. If exploitation evidence appears, we move to emergency change.

Security: I will confirm the testing and business constraints with the service owner.

IT operations engineer: Record the authorized plan and escalation triggers in the change record.

Notice the professional language

CVE - A public identifier for a known cybersecurity vulnerability.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Cloud Cost Spike

Finance notices a 38 percent increase in monthly cloud spend.

Roles: Finance / Cloud engineer / IT operations engineer

Finance: Why did cloud cost jump? Did IT approve this?

Cloud engineer: Most of the increase is compute in the analytics environment and log retention in production.

IT operations engineer: The immediate issue is spend, but the operational issue is ownership. Several resources have no cost-center tags, so we cannot assign accountability confidently.

Finance: Can you cut it today?

IT operations engineer: We can stop idle non-production instances today, reduce excessive log retention where policy allows, and bring a tagging enforcement plan by Friday. I would not delete storage until owners confirm retention requirements.

Finance: I will identify resource owners before any cost reduction changes.

IT operations engineer: Include retention and availability requirements in the proposed actions.

Notice the professional language

Cost conversations need evidence, ownership, and guardrails.

Do not promise savings by deleting resources without retention review.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Kubernetes Incident: Crashing Pods

A containerized internal tool fails after a deployment.

Roles: Developer / Platform engineer / IT operations engineer

Developer: The deployment is broken. The pods keep restarting.

Platform engineer: The readiness probe is failing, and the logs show missing environment variables. We still need to check the container termination reason.

IT operations engineer: A failed readiness probe can remove a pod from service endpoints; it does not itself explain container restarts. Let's inspect termination events and any liveness or startup probe failures before assigning a cause.

Developer: Should we roll back?

IT operations engineer: Let's compare rollback and configuration repair using the incident procedure, evidence, and approved recovery options. The missing configuration is a finding; the full failure sequence still needs confirmation.

Developer: I will capture the termination reason and current deployment configuration.

IT operations engineer: Bring those to the incident lead so recovery follows the evidence.

Notice the professional language

The learner distinguishes platform behavior from application configuration.

Incident language should prioritize restoration, then investigation.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Phishing and Possible Account Compromise

A user clicked a suspicious link and entered credentials.

Roles: User / Service desk / IT operations engineer

User: I think I made a mistake. I entered my password on a weird page.

Service desk: Thank you for reporting quickly. Please do not change anything else yet.

IT operations engineer: We will follow the approved account-compromise response, including authorized containment and evidence handling. I will connect you with security through the established channel and explain the reporting steps.

User: Am I in trouble?

IT operations engineer: The priority is containment and evidence. Reporting quickly helps us protect your account and other users.

User: I will stay on the approved support channel.

IT operations engineer: Thank you. We will confirm the handoff to security and explain the next steps.

Notice the professional language

Good security communication reduces shame so users report faster.

Containment steps should be specific but not overly alarming.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Backup Restore Test: RPO Mismatch

A restore test shows that the system can recover, but with more data loss than expected.

Roles: Business owner / Database admin / IT operations engineer

Business owner: The restore worked, so are we good?

Database admin: The restore completed, but the latest usable backup is six hours old.

IT operations engineer: The restore completed within our recovery-time target, but the latest recovered data are older than the agreed recovery-point objective. We need to report those two results separately.

Business owner: I did not understand that difference.

IT operations engineer: RTO is the recovery-time objective. RPO describes the acceptable recovery point, commonly expressed as a time-based data-loss window. We need to review the recovery design against the business requirements and escalate the gap.

Business owner: I will confirm the business recovery targets in writing.

IT operations engineer: Then we can review the tested results against the agreed requirements.

Notice the professional language

RPO - Recovery point objective: the maximum acceptable data loss measured in time.

RTO - Recovery time objective: the maximum acceptable restoration time.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 09 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Change Advisory: Firewall Rule Request

A project team wants a broad firewall opening before a launch.

Roles: Project lead / Security architect / IT operations engineer

Project lead: We need to open the firewall to the vendor range today, or the launch slips.

Security architect: The requested range is too broad.

IT operations engineer: Can we narrow by source, destination, port, protocol, and time window? If the vendor cannot provide that, we should treat this as a high-risk exception with monitoring and an expiration date.

Project lead: What is the business impact of waiting?

IT operations engineer: Launch delay is one impact. The other impact is exposing internal services more widely than necessary. The decision should name both risks and the owner who accepts the exception.

Project lead: I will ask the vendor for the specific connectivity requirements.

IT operations engineer: We can assess the narrowed request through the normal security review.

Notice the professional language

A change review is not only a technical approval; it records risk ownership.

Use precise constraint language: source, destination, port, protocol, duration.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 10 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Post-Incident Review: Blame vs Learning

A failed manual change caused an outage. The team is reviewing what happened.

Roles: Manager / Engineer / IT operations engineer

Manager: Who made the change?

Engineer: I did, but I followed the old runbook.

IT operations engineer: The action matters, but the improvement question is broader. Why did the runbook allow a manual step without peer review, validation, or rollback verification?

Manager: So what should the action items be?

IT operations engineer: Update the runbook, add automated validation, require peer review for that command, and create an alert that detects the bad state within two minutes.

Manager: I will draft those actions with owners and verification criteria.

IT operations engineer: Review them against the actual failure sequence before treating the investigation as complete.

Notice the professional language

Root-cause language should include process and detection gaps.

Action items need owners, due dates, and verification, not just good intentions.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 11 / 7 SPEAKING TURNS

Vendor Escalation: SaaS Degradation

A critical SaaS vendor reports a regional degradation affecting SSO logins.

Roles: Business stakeholder / Vendor manager / IT operations engineer / Stakeholder

Business stakeholder: Why can't IT fix this?

Vendor manager: The issue is in the vendor's region. We do not control their identity gateway.

IT operations engineer: Our role is mitigation and communication. We are checking alternate login paths, monitoring the vendor status page, and collecting affected-user counts so we can escalate with evidence.

Stakeholder: When will it be fixed?

IT operations engineer: The vendor has not provided an ETA. I will give the next update in 30 minutes, or sooner if the status changes.

Business stakeholder: I will collect the affected-user counts and current service impact.

IT operations engineer: That will make the vendor escalation and our next stakeholder update more useful.

Notice the professional language

When a vendor owns the fix, IT can still own communication, impact tracking, and mitigations.

Avoid inventing ETAs under pressure.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 12 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Executive Update: Risk, Impact, and Decision

A CIO asks for a short update during a major email outage.

Roles: CIO / IT operations engineer

CIO: Give me the short version.

IT operations engineer: Email delivery is delayed for about 40 percent of users in this fictional incident. Current checks show queued mail, but we have not reconciled every message. We are investigating the filtering-service dependency with the vendor and reviewing approved continuity options.

CIO: What decision do you need?

IT operations engineer: We need an authorized decision on the available continuity options after security and service owners assess them. I will describe the operational effect and control implications of each option before requesting approval.

CIO: I will confirm the business owners needed for that decision.

IT operations engineer: I will bring the assessed options and keep the incident status current.

Notice the professional language

Executive updates should include impact, confidence, mitigation, risk, and requested decision.

A short update can still be technically precise.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

SHARED CASE

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

SHARED CASE

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Identity, Access, and Permissions

SHARED CASE

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report. A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

SHARED CASE

Two cloud options cost $800 and $1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The $1,050 option includes backup storage; the $800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

SHARED CASE

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

SHARED CASE

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

SHARED CASE

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for ... . The correct information is ... .

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

SHARED CASE

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Narrowing the invoice-export incident

The service desk clarifies the lesson's ticket: sign-in works, invoice export does not, and other functions are untested.

01 · Service desk analyst: Your ticket says the system is down. Could you describe the action that fails?

02 · Billing specialist: I can sign in, but I cannot export invoices from the application.

03 · Service desk analyst: Thank you. Have you checked any other functions, or only sign-in and export?

04 · Billing specialist: Only those two. I don't know whether anyone else has the same issue.

05 · Service desk analyst: I'll record an invoice-export incident rather than a confirmed outage of the whole system.

06 · Billing specialist: Is that different from a service request for a new export feature?

07 · Service desk analyst: Yes. You're reporting a function that isn't working, not requesting a new capability.

08 · Billing specialist: Can you tell me when it will be fixed under the SLA?

09 · Service desk analyst: I need to check the applicable service agreement and triage the impact before discussing timing.

10 · Billing specialist: Understood. I'll describe the failed action in the ticket without expanding the affected scope.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A printer queue needs an impact check

A separate fictional office: one receptionist reports a stuck label-printing job; another printer has not been tested.

01 · Service desk analyst: Which printer is affected, and what happens when you submit a label job?

02 · Reception supervisor: The reception label job stays in the queue. I haven't tested another printer.

03 · Service desk analyst: Does the ticket concern a single stuck job or every job in that queue?

04 · Reception supervisor: I only know about my job. I shouldn't have written that printing is unavailable everywhere.

05 · Service desk analyst: That's useful clarification. What work is currently blocked by this incident?

06 · Reception supervisor: I need these labels for reception work, but I haven't assessed the wider impact.

07 · Service desk analyst: I'll capture that limitation and ask the support team to check the queue.

08 · Reception supervisor: Should I raise a separate problem record because this feels familiar?

09 · Service desk analyst: Let's first check earlier tickets. A similar symptom doesn't establish a shared underlying problem.

10 · Reception supervisor: I'll provide the job reference and avoid creating duplicate tickets while you review it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A request for equipment is not a repair

A separate fictional onboarding case: a hiring coordinator requests a second monitor for a new starter; no existing device has failed.

01 · Hiring coordinator: I marked this urgent incident because the new starter needs a second monitor.

02 · Service desk analyst: Has any assigned equipment failed, or are you requesting additional equipment?

03 · Hiring coordinator: Nothing has failed. This is an additional monitor, and approval hasn't been checked.

04 · Service desk analyst: Then let's describe it as a service request and identify the approval route.

05 · Hiring coordinator: Will changing the category guarantee that the equipment arrives before the start date?

06 · Service desk analyst: No. Categorization clarifies the work; stock, approval, and fulfillment timing still need checking.

07 · Hiring coordinator: What information should I supply so the request can be assessed properly?

08 · Service desk analyst: Please provide the role's requirement and intended start date, without assuming the request is approved.

09 · Hiring coordinator: I'll add those details and ask who can authorize the equipment.

10 · Service desk analyst: I'll confirm the next step and applicable service expectations once the request is reviewed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

A ticket says "the system is down." The requester can sign in but cannot export invoices. Other functions have not been checked.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which action fails, and what message do you see? I understand that sign-in works but invoice export does not. When did the problem start, and who else is affected?

Scenario 2 | A missing shared-folder shortcut

In a fictional office, an employee's shared-folder shortcut no longer opens. The folder's web link still works. Only one device has been checked, and no files are known to be missing.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Clarify the failed action and affected scope.

Role B: You are the records coordinator. Explain the two observed outcomes and ask how the incident will be described.

Possible opening: The shortcut fails, but the web link opens; let's separate those two observations.

Success checks

- State both observed outcomes.

- Avoid claiming data loss or an organization-wide outage.

- Agree a precise ticket description and the next diagnostic question.

Add a complication: A manager wants the ticket labeled data loss even though no missing file has been identified.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The VPN difference is not a DNS diagnosis

Engineers examine the lesson's internal application, reachable in the office but not through the VPN.

01 · Service desk lead: People can reach the application in the office, but not through the VPN.

02 · Network engineer: That comparison is useful. It doesn't yet establish whether DNS is responsible.

03 · Service desk lead: A colleague already announced a DNS fault. Should I repeat that in the update?

04 · Network engineer: No. Say the failure is observed on the VPN path and the cause is unconfirmed.

05 · Service desk lead: Could a gateway or firewall issue also fit the symptom we have?

06 · Network engineer: Those are possible hypotheses, not findings. We need evidence from the affected connection.

07 · Service desk lead: What comparison would help without changing several settings at the same time?

08 · Network engineer: Check name resolution and connection results for the same application from both paths.

09 · Service desk lead: I'll preserve the observed difference and remove the unsupported diagnosis from my summary.

10 · Network engineer: I'll investigate the hypotheses and report which tests support or weaken each one.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

One hostname works, another does not

A separate fictional network test: a laptop reaches the intranet hostname but not a reporting hostname; no DNS response has been inspected.

01 · Network technician: The intranet opens, but the reporting hostname doesn't. I suspect a name-resolution issue.

02 · Application engineer: That's possible, but have we inspected the DNS response for the reporting name?

03 · Network technician: Not yet. I only have the browser result from this laptop.

04 · Application engineer: Then don't describe a DNS failure as confirmed. The browser result covers several possible stages.

05 · Network technician: Would a successful intranet visit rule out the gateway as a cause?

06 · Application engineer: It shows one path worked, not that every destination uses an identical path.

07 · Network technician: I'll collect the reporting lookup result and the time of the failed attempt.

08 · Application engineer: Good. Keep the application name and test device consistent so the evidence is comparable.

09 · Network technician: We can then decide whether to investigate resolution, routing, or the application response.

10 · Application engineer: Exactly. The update should distinguish our observation from the explanation we're still testing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A firewall change and an uncertain cause

A separate fictional incident: connection errors appeared after a firewall change, but no rule-level evidence has been reviewed.

01 · Incident coordinator: Connection errors began after the firewall change. Can we say the change caused them?

02 · Network engineer: We can report the timing, but we haven't linked the errors to a particular rule.

03 · Incident coordinator: The sequence looks convincing. What evidence would make the causal statement stronger?

04 · Network engineer: We need affected connection details and relevant firewall logs, compared with the approved change.

05 · Incident coordinator: Should I ask users to bypass the firewall while we investigate?

06 · Network engineer: No. We should use the authorized incident process, not invent an unreviewed workaround.

07 · Incident coordinator: Then I'll say the change is a hypothesis under investigation, not the established root cause.

08 · Network engineer: Please include the observed error period and avoid claiming every connection is affected.

09 · Incident coordinator: I'll request the evidence through the incident channel and keep the scope bounded.

10 · Network engineer: I'll review it and explain what we can actually conclude before recommending any change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Staff can reach an internal application on the office network but not through the VPN. Someone announces that DNS is the cause without testing it.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The problem appears when users connect through the VPN. DNS is one possible cause, but we have not confirmed it. Let's record the tests and distinguish findings from hypotheses.

Scenario 2 | The wired-versus-wireless comparison

In a fictional office, one laptop reaches a file portal over a wired connection but not over wireless. Both tests used the same account. No other device or network log has been checked.

Role A: You are the network analyst. Separate the confirmed comparison from possible causes.

Role B: You are the support lead. Challenge the claim that the wireless access point is definitely faulty.

Possible opening: The same laptop and account work over wired access, but that does not yet identify the wireless failure's cause.

Success checks

- Preserve the single-device scope.

- Describe an equipment fault as a hypothesis only.

- Agree another bounded check before recommending replacement.

Add a complication: Someone proposes replacing equipment immediately because the two results look decisive.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Requesting the reporting role

The lesson's temporary analyst needs a monthly download and has requested administrator access; a reporting role may suffice.

01 · Temporary analyst: Could you give me administrator access so I can download the monthly report?

02 · Access administrator: Please request the specific reporting function instead. We need to check the narrower role first.

03 · Temporary analyst: I can authenticate successfully, so why can't I already download the file?

04 · Access administrator: Authentication verifies your sign-in; authorization determines which actions your account may perform.

05 · Temporary analyst: Then could you assess whether the reporting role authorizes the download I need?

06 · Access administrator: Yes. Please include the report name, business purpose, and required access period in the request.

07 · Temporary analyst: I don't have approval yet. Should I describe the role as already agreed?

08 · Access administrator: No. The request should go to the relevant owner for approval under our access process.

09 · Temporary analyst: I'll submit the bounded request and explain why administrator rights may be unnecessary.

10 · Access administrator: I'll review the least-privilege option without promising access before authorization is confirmed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Read access for a contractor review

A separate fictional project: a contractor must review one test dashboard for a week; editing is not part of the requested work.

01 · Project manager: Could we arrange dashboard access for the contractor's one-week review of our test results?

02 · IAM specialist: Which dashboard is needed, and does the contractor need to edit anything?

03 · Project manager: Only the test dashboard. The assignment is review, so editing isn't part of the request.

04 · IAM specialist: Then let's assess a read-only role rather than a broader workspace permission.

05 · Project manager: Can you copy another engineer's access to make the setup quicker?

06 · IAM specialist: That could include unrelated authorization. Least privilege means matching access to this specific work.

07 · Project manager: I'll identify the dashboard owner and ask them to review the read-only request.

08 · IAM specialist: Please include the one-week duration so removal or expiry can be addressed explicitly.

09 · Project manager: I'll also state that the start depends on approval, not assume today's access is guaranteed.

10 · IAM specialist: Good. I'll check the available role and return any missing information before provisioning.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Ending access after a temporary assignment

A separate fictional service team: an analyst's temporary reporting assignment has ended, but the corresponding role remains listed on the account.

01 · Service owner: The temporary assignment ended, but the reporting role is still listed on the analyst's account.

02 · Access administrator: Are you requesting removal of that role only, or closure of the entire account?

03 · Service owner: The role only. I don't have information about the analyst's other work.

04 · Access administrator: That's an important limit. Please identify the assignment and the role in your request.

05 · Service owner: Could you remove it before the next access review, once the owner approves?

06 · Access administrator: I'll check the authorization route and confirm timing rather than promise an unapproved change.

07 · Service owner: Would disabling authentication be a simpler way to enforce least privilege?

08 · Access administrator: It would affect all account use. Your request concerns one authorization, not every sign-in.

09 · Service owner: Understood. I'll keep the requested action narrow and ask the owner to confirm removal.

10 · Access administrator: I'll report the role's status after the approved action, including any work still pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Identity, Access, and Permissions

A temporary analyst requests administrator access to download a monthly report. A reporting role may provide the necessary access.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could you confirm the report and actions you need? The reporting role may be sufficient. Please include the requested end date so the access owner can review the request.

Scenario 2 | A service account with too broad a request

A fictional overnight job needs to read one inventory table. Its request asks for database-owner rights. The data owner has not reviewed the request, and no write operation is required by the supplied job description.

Role A: You maintain the job. Request assessment of read access for the named table.

Role B: You administer access. Ask for purpose and approval, and explain why the broader permission is not assumed necessary.

Possible opening: The job description requires reading one table, so could we assess that narrower permission first?

Success checks

- Tie the request to the stated read operation.

- Keep data-owner approval pending.

- Reject speculative future needs as evidence for current broad access.

Add a complication: The project lead says broad access would avoid future requests, although future needs are undefined.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Comparing cloud estimates with the same backup scope

The lesson's cloud estimates are $800 and $1,050 monthly; only the second includes backup storage.

01 · Procurement analyst: The first cloud option is $800 monthly, so it looks $250 cheaper than the second.

02 · Cloud engineer: The second estimate includes backup storage. The first leaves that cost out.

03 · Procurement analyst: Then the price difference doesn't yet compare the same service scope?

04 · Cloud engineer: Correct. We need a comparable backup allowance before calling either option less expensive overall.

05 · Procurement analyst: Should I also check whether the VM size and region assumptions match?

06 · Cloud engineer: Yes. Those details affect the comparison, and we haven't established that they are identical.

07 · Procurement analyst: Could tagging tell us which team should own each cost after deployment?

08 · Cloud engineer: It could support cost allocation if we define and apply the tags consistently.

09 · Procurement analyst: I'll request an aligned estimate instead of recommending the apparently cheaper figure today.

10 · Cloud engineer: Then we can explain the real tradeoffs without hiding the missing backup component.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An idle test VM still appears on the estimate

A separate fictional test environment compares a continuously available VM with a proposed scheduled VM; restart time has not been measured.

01 · Product owner: The scheduled VM option looks attractive because we don't run tests overnight.

02 · Infrastructure engineer: It may reduce running time, but we need to compare availability and restart effort too.

03 · Product owner: Does stopping the VM mean every associated cloud cost stops as well?

04 · Infrastructure engineer: We shouldn't assume that. The estimate must identify storage and other retained resources separately.

05 · Product owner: The continuously available option avoids waiting for a restart, whereas the scheduled one may not.

06 · Infrastructure engineer: Exactly. We haven't measured that restart time or checked the test team's access pattern.

07 · Product owner: Let's ask about early test runs before accepting a narrower availability window.

08 · Infrastructure engineer: I'll also check resource tagging so the comparison includes the same environment in both cases.

09 · Product owner: Then we'll compare monthly cost, availability, and the unmeasured restart impact side by side.

10 · Infrastructure engineer: Good. We have a candidate saving, not a verified recommendation to switch.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Container packaging is not a complete operating cost

A separate fictional service review compares a container deployment proposal with an existing VM estimate; monitoring is included only in the VM estimate.

01 · Platform engineer: The container proposal lists compute costs, while the VM estimate also includes monitoring.

02 · Finance partner: Can we remove monitoring from the VM estimate to make the container proposal look competitive?

03 · Platform engineer: We should compare the required operating scope, not remove necessary items to favor one option.

04 · Finance partner: So both proposals need the same monitoring assumption before we discuss total cost?

05 · Platform engineer: Yes. Container packaging doesn't by itself establish a cheaper or simpler operating model.

06 · Finance partner: What other tradeoff should the decision group hear besides the monthly estimate?

07 · Platform engineer: We should assess the team's support responsibilities and deployment requirements for each option.

08 · Finance partner: Those haven't been costed yet, so I'll identify them as open items.

09 · Platform engineer: I'll ask the service owner to confirm the required scope and region assumptions.

10 · Finance partner: Then our comparison can separate priced components from operational questions that remain unresolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Two cloud options cost $800 and $1,050 per month in a planning estimate. Only the second estimate includes backup storage.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The estimates do not yet cover the same items. The $1,050 option includes backup storage; the $800 option does not. Let's compare equivalent configurations before recommending one.

Scenario 2 | Two storage estimates use different retention

In a fictional planning exercise, storage option A assumes thirty days of backups and option B assumes ninety. Both use the same estimated daily data volume. The required retention period is not yet agreed.

Role A: You are the cloud analyst. Explain why the totals cannot yet establish the cheaper equivalent option.

Role B: You are the service owner. Discuss how to obtain the retention requirement before selecting an estimate.

Possible opening: The daily data assumption matches, but the backup retention periods do not.

Success checks

- Name the thirty-day and ninety-day difference.

- Keep required retention unresolved.

- Agree a like-for-like comparison after the requirement is confirmed.

Add a complication: A stakeholder proposes labeling the lower estimate best value before agreeing retention.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One hundred eighty is not the whole fleet

The lesson's patch deployment reached 180 of 200 laptops; twelve were offline and eight reported installation errors.

01 · IT manager: Can I tell the department that the laptop patch deployment is complete?

02 · Endpoint administrator: Not yet. It reached 180 of 200 managed laptops; twenty still need attention.

03 · IT manager: Are all twenty failures, or do we need different follow-up actions?

04 · Endpoint administrator: Twelve were offline, while eight reported installation errors. Those are different pending categories.

05 · IT manager: Does the MDM report confirm that every successful installation has been functionally tested?

06 · Endpoint administrator: It reports deployment status. We shouldn't extend that into an unverified claim about every function.

07 · IT manager: Please separate the asset inventory count from the installation and verification status.

08 · Endpoint administrator: I will. I'll review the error group and arrange follow-up for the offline laptops.

09 · IT manager: Can you promise all twenty will be finished in the next maintenance window?

10 · Endpoint administrator: I can plan follow-up, but availability and error resolution must be checked before committing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A server patch installed but restart pending

A separate fictional server maintenance record shows the update installed; the planned restart and application check remain pending.

01 · Service owner: The patch shows installed. May I announce that maintenance is finished for the application?

02 · Server administrator: The installation is complete, but the restart and application check are still pending.

03 · Service owner: Then installed and ready for normal service are different states in this record?

04 · Server administrator: Yes. We need to communicate the remaining steps within the agreed maintenance window.

05 · Service owner: Has anyone confirmed that the application will pass its check after the restart?

06 · Server administrator: No. That check hasn't happened, so a successful result cannot be reported yet.

07 · Service owner: The update is installed; the restart and application check are still pending.

08 · Server administrator: Please don't imply a new outage or a failed check either; neither is recorded.

09 · Service owner: Understood. Who will supply the next status once the planned steps are complete?

10 · Server administrator: I'll provide the restart result and the application owner's check, with any unresolved issue separated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A device missing from the managed inventory

A separate fictional inventory review finds a listed laptop absent from the MDM report; its current location and management status are unknown.

01 · Asset coordinator: This laptop appears in the asset inventory but not in the current MDM report.

02 · Endpoint administrator: Then we can't include it among devices with confirmed patch status from that report.

03 · Asset coordinator: Could we mark it retired so the deployment percentage looks complete?

04 · Endpoint administrator: No. Its status is unknown. A missing management record doesn't establish retirement.

05 · Asset coordinator: What work is complete in this review, and what remains for follow-up?

06 · Endpoint administrator: We've identified the discrepancy. We still need to confirm ownership, location, and management status.

07 · Asset coordinator: I'll ask the recorded owner about the device through our normal asset process.

08 · Endpoint administrator: I'll check whether the management record uses another identifier without changing the inventory prematurely.

09 · Asset coordinator: Our update should show one unresolved inventory item, not an assumed patch success.

10 · Endpoint administrator: Exactly. We'll reconcile the records before revising the managed-device count or completion claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

A patch reached 180 of 200 managed laptops. Twelve were offline; eight reported installation errors. A manager asks if deployment is complete.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: The patch is installed on 180 laptops. Twelve were offline and eight returned errors. Deployment is not complete; I'll separate those groups in the follow-up report.

Scenario 2 | The kiosk configuration is only partly applied

A fictional deployment targeted ten kiosks. Seven report the new configuration, two were offline, and one has not returned a status. No functional checks have been completed.

Role A: You manage endpoints. Give a precise progress report and distinguish missing status from failure.

Role B: You own the kiosk service. Ask what remains before calling the rollout complete.

Possible opening: Seven kiosks report the configuration, but three statuses and the functional checks still need attention.

Success checks

- Account for all ten kiosks.

- Do not equate silence with success.

- Separate configuration status from functional verification and agree follow-up.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to count the silent kiosk as successful because it returned no error.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Handing over an unconfirmed sign-in alert

The lesson's analyst hands an unusual sign-in alert to the response team; the account owner has not confirmed the activity.

01 · Security analyst: I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The account owner hasn't confirmed whether the activity was theirs.

02 · Incident responder: Is compromise confirmed, or are we reviewing an alert that still needs validation?

03 · Security analyst: Only the alert is confirmed. I haven't established unauthorized access from it.

04 · Incident responder: Please identify the alert reference and where the relevant audit log can be reviewed.

05 · Security analyst: I'll attach those references in the restricted incident record, not copy sensitive details into general chat.

06 · Incident responder: What action are you asking the response team to take next?

07 · Security analyst: Review the sign-in evidence and coordinate the owner check through the response process.

08 · Incident responder: I'll take that review. Has any containment action already been reported in this handoff?

09 · Security analyst: No containment is stated here. Please verify the record before assuming any action occurred.

10 · Incident responder: Understood: unconfirmed activity, evidence references in the incident record, and validation assigned to me.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A vulnerability result without an exploit finding

A separate fictional security review: a scanner flags one test server; no exploitation evidence has been examined.

01 · Vulnerability analyst: The scanner flagged one test server. I'm handing the finding to you for validation.

02 · Server owner: Does the finding mean someone has already exploited the server's vulnerability?

03 · Vulnerability analyst: No. The scan result is not evidence that exploitation occurred, and that question hasn't been examined.

04 · Server owner: What information will help me confirm whether the finding applies to this asset?

05 · Vulnerability analyst: The scanner reference, asset identifier, and reported software detail are in the restricted review record.

06 · Server owner: I'll verify the asset configuration. Should I also promise a patch date now?

07 · Vulnerability analyst: Please assess the finding and maintenance requirements first. We haven't established a feasible date.

08 · Server owner: Then my immediate task is validation, with remediation planning dependent on the result.

09 · Vulnerability analyst: Correct. Return the evidence and any unresolved questions so the risk owner can review them.

10 · Server owner: I accept that handoff and won't describe the scan as a confirmed compromise.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A SIEM alert with an incomplete time range

A separate fictional monitoring handoff: an analyst has saved an alert and ten minutes of audit logs; earlier activity has not been reviewed.

01 · Monitoring analyst: I've saved the SIEM alert and ten minutes of related audit logs for your review.

02 · Response lead: Does that cover the full event, or only the window you examined so far?

03 · Monitoring analyst: Only that window. I haven't reviewed earlier activity, so the beginning is unknown.

04 · Response lead: Thank you. We shouldn't call the available extract a complete incident timeline.

05 · Monitoring analyst: I'll mark the coverage limits and link the original alert in the restricted record.

06 · Response lead: What remains for the next analyst besides checking the entries already collected?

07 · Monitoring analyst: They need to assess whether a wider time range is relevant and gather it appropriately.

08 · Response lead: I'll assign that assessment and preserve the existing extract as part of the evidence.

09 · Monitoring analyst: Could you repeat the open point so I know the handoff is clear?

10 · Response lead: The alert and ten-minute extract are available; event scope and earlier activity remain unestablished.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

An analyst notices an unusual sign-in alert and sends it to the response team. The account owner has not yet confirmed the activity.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: I'm handing over an unusual sign-in alert. The timestamp and alert details are attached; the account owner's confirmation is pending. Please acknowledge receipt and confirm who will coordinate the investigation.

Scenario 2 | An attachment report before analysis

In a fictional company, an employee reported an unexpected attachment. The message reference is preserved in a restricted ticket. The attachment has not been analyzed, and the employee's interaction with it is unknown.

Role A: You are the service desk analyst. Hand over the report without labeling the attachment malicious.

Role B: You are the security responder. Confirm the evidence location and the two unresolved questions.

Possible opening: We have an unexpected-attachment report, but no analysis result or confirmed interaction history yet.

Success checks

- Keep maliciousness and user interaction unconfirmed.

- Use the restricted evidence reference instead of distributing the attachment.

- Confirm who will handle analysis and the interaction check.

Add a complication: Someone asks you to circulate the attachment broadly so colleagues can inspect it themselves.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Correcting Tuesday to Thursday

The lesson's change notice incorrectly announced Tuesday; the approved maintenance window is Thursday and users already received the notice.

01 · Change coordinator: I sent the wrong maintenance date. The notice said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday.

02 · Service owner: Users already received it. Please make the correction clear rather than silently replacing the notice.

03 · Change coordinator: I'll acknowledge the error and identify Thursday as the approved maintenance day.

04 · Service owner: Will you also change the technical runbook to match the mistaken Tuesday announcement?

05 · Change coordinator: No. The communication was wrong; it doesn't authorize changing the approved schedule.

06 · Service owner: Good. We should not create a second change while trying to repair the first message.

07 · Change coordinator: I'll use the original distribution route and label the new notice as a correction.

08 · Service owner: Please avoid inventing a new start time if the correction only concerns the day.

09 · Change coordinator: Agreed. I'll preserve the approved details and make the date correction explicit.

10 · Service owner: Once sent, confirm distribution so the support team can answer questions consistently.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Rollback available is not rollback completed

A separate fictional release: an update said rollback was complete, but the runbook only described an available rollback option; no execution is recorded.

01 · Release manager: My status update said rollback was complete. The record actually shows only that a rollback option exists.

02 · On-call engineer: Then users may believe we restored the previous version when no execution is recorded.

03 · Release manager: I'll correct that directly: rollback is available, not confirmed as performed.

04 · On-call engineer: Can you also avoid stating that the service is restored on that basis?

05 · Release manager: Yes. Recovery status needs its own evidence; the runbook isn't proof of an outcome.

06 · On-call engineer: What should the next update say about the release decision?

07 · Release manager: That the current status is being verified and any rollback decision will follow the authorized process.

08 · On-call engineer: I'll check the execution record and service evidence without assuming the earlier message was accurate.

09 · Release manager: I'll acknowledge my incorrect wording through the same incident channel.

10 · On-call engineer: Then we'll issue a verified status rather than let a possible action become a reported event.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Closing the incident did not close the problem

A separate fictional service incident is resolved, but the underlying-cause investigation remains open; an update mistakenly says all work is finished.

01 · Problem manager: The update says all work is finished, but the underlying-cause investigation is still open.

02 · Service coordinator: I confused restoring service with completing the problem investigation. I'll correct that wording.

03 · Problem manager: Please retain the confirmed restoration rather than making it sound as though service failed again.

04 · Service coordinator: So the corrected message should separate the resolved incident from the open problem record?

05 · Problem manager: Exactly. Users need an accurate service status and visibility of the remaining investigation.

06 · Service coordinator: Should I name a root cause to make the update feel more complete?

07 · Problem manager: No. An unresolved cause should remain unresolved in the message, however inconvenient that sounds.

08 · Service coordinator: I'll explain that investigation continues and link the problem record for authorized readers.

09 · Problem manager: I'll supply the next verified finding when available, rather than promise a conclusion today.

10 · Service coordinator: Thanks. I'll send an explicit correction and preserve both statuses accurately.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

A change notice gave the wrong maintenance date. It said Tuesday, but the approved window is Thursday. Users have already received it.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: Please disregard the Tuesday date in my earlier notice. The approved maintenance window is Thursday. I'm sorry for the confusion; the corrected notice below includes the exact time and time zone.

Scenario 2 | A notice names the wrong affected service

A fictional change notice names the payroll portal, but the approved change concerns the training portal only. The notice has been sent. No payroll work is in the approved scope.

Role A: You coordinate changes. Acknowledge the incorrect service name and state the correct scope.

Role B: You lead support. Ask how users will receive the correction and how the approved record will remain intact.

Possible opening: The notice incorrectly named payroll; the approved change concerns the training portal only.

Success checks

- Name the communication error clearly.
- Keep approved scope separate from the incorrect notice.
- Agree to send an explicit correction through the original distribution route.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests adding payroll maintenance now to make the original notice accurate.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Normal CPU does not measure checkout speed

The lesson's service shows normal server CPU while users report slow checkout.

01 · Product manager: The server CPU graph is normal. Doesn't that prove checkout is healthy?

02 · Site reliability engineer: It measures processor use, not the entire experience of completing a checkout.

03 · Product manager: Then the metric and the user reports aren't necessarily contradicting each other?

04 · Site reliability engineer: Correct. A delay elsewhere in the request path may not appear as high CPU.

05 · Product manager: Would a trace help explain that request path in plain terms?

06 · Site reliability engineer: Yes. A trace follows stages of a request; a log records particular events.

07 · Product manager: So we need checkout timing evidence, rather than another claim based on the CPU chart.

08 · Site reliability engineer: Exactly. We should inspect relevant metrics, logs, and traces before identifying a cause.

09 · Product manager: I'll stop calling the dashboard proof that users are mistaken.

10 · Site reliability engineer: I'll investigate the reported experience and distinguish confirmed timing from possible explanations.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A running pod is not a successful purchase

A separate fictional Kubernetes service: its pods are running, but no customer-journey test has been reviewed.

01 · Platform engineer: The dashboard says the pods are running. The release coordinator wants to call the service verified.

02 · Service owner: Running describes the workload's state, not whether a customer can complete a purchase.

03 · Platform engineer: Could you explain that distinction for the release meeting without platform terminology?

04 · Service owner: The software has started, but we haven't checked that the intended task works from beginning to end.

05 · Platform engineer: Then a normal infrastructure metric can't replace the customer-journey test we haven't reviewed.

06 · Service owner: Right. We need evidence at the level of the claim we're making.

07 · Platform engineer: I'll bring the workload status and mark the purchase verification as pending.

08 · Service owner: Please include any relevant trace when the test runs so we can locate a failure.

09 · Platform engineer: And if the test fails, we'll use logs for specific events rather than guess from pod status.

10 · Service owner: Exactly. Let's communicate two separate checks instead of compressing them into one green label.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An error budget is not permission to ignore users

A separate fictional reliability review: a service remains within its agreed monthly error budget, but users have reported a new failure pattern.

01 · Release lead: We still have error budget remaining. Can we ignore the new failure reports?

02 · Reliability engineer: No. The budget tracks allowed unreliability against our chosen objective; it doesn't make individual failures irrelevant.

03 · Release lead: So being within the monthly limit isn't the same as every workflow working correctly?

04 · Reliability engineer: Exactly. A monthly metric can hide a new pattern or a problem affecting a smaller group.

05 · Release lead: What evidence should we request before deciding whether another release can proceed?

06 · Reliability engineer: The affected workflow, timing, and related logs or traces, alongside the current objective measurements.

07 · Release lead: I'll ask for that review without claiming the budget itself grants release approval.

08 · Reliability engineer: Good. The decision should consider the new evidence and our agreed release process.

09 · Release lead: I'll describe the remaining budget as context, not as a dismissal of the reports.

10 · Reliability engineer: Then we can assess the actual risk without confusing a metric with a decision.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

A service dashboard shows normal server CPU usage, but users report slow checkout. A colleague says the dashboard proves the service is healthy.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: CPU usage tells us about one part of the system. It does not measure the whole checkout experience. Let's compare it with request latency and errors for the affected period.

Scenario 2 | Averages hide a slow group

In a fictional dashboard, average request time is unchanged, but five saved user traces show long waits at checkout. The sample's representativeness and the cause are unknown.

Role A: You are the observability engineer. Explain how an average differs from individual request traces.

Role B: You are the product lead. Ask what the five traces establish and what further evidence is needed.

Possible opening: The average is unchanged, but these five traces show delays that the average alone doesn't explain.

Success checks

- Distinguish an aggregate metric from request-level evidence.

- Keep the affected population and cause uncertain.

- Agree a bounded investigation without dismissing the observed delays.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants to claim that every customer is affected based on the five traces.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

Open this course's AI prompt workshop

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: General IT English

Professional audience: IT operations, service desk, infrastructure, cloud, endpoint, security, and platform teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Service Desk Escalation: 'VPN Is Broken'

Original fictional setting: A remote employee reports that the VPN connects, but the finance system will not load.

Professional roles: User / Service desk / IT operations engineer

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

User: The VPN is broken again. I cannot get to finance.

Service desk: I understand the impact. Can I confirm one detail: does the VPN show connected, or does the connection fail completely?

User: It says connected.

IT operations engineer: Then we should avoid calling this a VPN outage yet. It may be DNS, routing, firewall, or the finance app itself. Are other internal sites loading?

User: The intranet loads, but finance times out.

IT operations engineer: Thank you. I will update the ticket as 'VPN connected; finance app unreachable over VPN for one user.' I am checking whether this is user-specific or app-wide before escalating.

User: I will check the application status with the service owner.

IT operations engineer: Please keep the ticket scope precise while we determine how many users are affected.

Vocabulary in this exchange: DNS: The system that resolves names such as app.example.com to network addresses. / VPN: A protected tunnel that allows remote users or sites to access private resources. / Firewall: A control that allows, blocks, or inspects network traffic based on rules.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.

2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.

3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.

4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.

5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.

2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.

3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.

4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.

5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level